

STENDHAL

ROME, NAPLES AND FLORENCE

TRANSLATED BY
RICHARD N. COE



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JOHN CALDER

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Translator's Foreword

THE 'Italian Journey' in the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries was an adventure which few who possessed the means and the leisure were tempted to refuse. Italy, so accessible, yet at the same time so remote and (in Calabria at least) so primitive, was heir to such a wealth of traditions, that every traveller might find there something to satisfy his curiosity. For Gibbon or Montesquieu, there were the vestiges of Rome, the still-visible evidence of her power and of the grandeur or weakness of her political institutions. Pompei and Herculaneum had only recently come to light, to arouse the learned speculations of a Winckelmann, and at the same time to fill the coffers of the King of Naples. Misson, the protestant pastor, had travelled in search of art and culture, the learned Dr Burney in search of music, de Brosse in search of that whole heritage of courtiership and splendour which still lingered on from the flamboyant epoch of the Renaissance. And if the poets—Goethe, Byron, Shelley, to name only the greatest—found in Italy the incarnation of that new sweetness and sensuality which was to invade the literary consciousness of Europe in the age of Romanticism, the ordinary educated Englishman, Frenchman or German might walk the fields of Mantua or contemplate Lake Trasimene, and there discover, with an emotion no less real for being more traditional, the haunting echo of verses or the distant ring of battles familiar to him from the school-room.

Yet for Henri Beyle—known to us as Stendhal—Italy was more than an adventure, an excursion, or even a theory: Italy was the deepest and most powerful experience of his life; it was an ideal, a touchstone which he employed to test the value of every personality and of every institution; it was the symbol of all his aspirations, in music as in art, in politics no less than in love, but above all in that all-embracing sphere of activities, philosophical, social and sentimental, which he entitled *la chasse au bonheur*—the Pursuit of Happiness. For the greater part of his life, Stendhal could conceive of no perfect happiness outside the land of Italy.

Among those nations of Europe who had long felt the power and attraction of Italy, England, in the early years of the nineteenth century, was at the greatest disadvantage; for the wars of the French Revolution and of the Napoleonic era had closed the frontiers, and many a projected 'Grand Tour' had had to be cancelled or postponed. (Indeed, the few eager travellers

who had rashly taken advantage of the ephemeral Peace of Amiens to journey abroad had sometimes suffered heavily for their presumption, and—like Joseph Forsyth—had written their 'Journeys' and 'Memoirs' in the enforced idleness of a Napoleonic gaol.) In consequence, when peace was at last restored, there was a headlong rush to cross the Alps. Milan and Florence, Rome and Naples were thronged with English tourists, while hard upon their heels came Russians, Poles and others who had suffered from the twenty-year blockade; and the period 1815-1830 may well be called the Golden Age of travel in Italy.

Stendhal, on the other hand, had profited not a little from those very calamities which had so frustrated the enquiring or the restless spirits of St Petersburg and London. Born in Grenoble on January 23rd, 1783, he had come to Paris in search of adventure and experience a few weeks before the turn of the century—in fact, the first news which greeted him upon his arrival was that Napoleon had overthrown the disintegrating power of the *Directoire*, and had taken into his own hands the government of France. From the outset, Stendhal conceived an admiration for the First Consul which, though highly critical at times, was never wholly lost; and indeed, for the next fifteen years, the fortunes of the two men were to be closely, if indirectly, linked. None the less, Stendhal's first taste of Paris was one of bitter disappointment. He was friendless, almost penniless; worse still, disconcerted and bored. He lodged in a decrepit attic in the rue du Bac, with little food and no heating. Never of the strongest constitution, he soon contracted pleurisy; and that, indeed, might have been the end of Henri Beyle, but for the intervention of a distant cousin, Noël Daru, sometime secretary to the comte de Saint-Priest in Montpellier. Noël Daru was seventy years of age, and comparatively wealthy; he promptly rescued Henri Beyle from his perilous situation, installed him in his own comfortable house in the rue de Lille, and there introduced him to his sons Pierre and Martial.

Pierre Daru—later one of Napoleon's greatest civil administrators—was already an influential figure in the War Office, and, as soon as Beyle was recovered, the rising 'chef de la première division' used his power to obtain for his young cousin a post in his own department. But by this date, France stood already on the eve of the battle of Marengo; Napoleon had thrown the vanguard of his army across the Great Saint Bernard, and Daru was ordered to follow. And so, on the 7th of May, 1800, we find Henri Beyle, seventeen years of age and perched with desperate insecurity astride a bay horse, engulfed in the baggage-train of that extraordinary army. For the first time, Stendhal was headed southward into Italy.

A few days later, having come under fire from the guns of the Fort du Bard, and feeling like some hero out of Ariosto in spite of his ignominious civilian costume, Henri Beyle struggled into Ivrea. Having nothing better to do, and being filled to overflowing with curiosity, he went to the opera; and there, in that third-rate theatre, with its creaking stage, its down-at-heel players and its patchy orchestra, came the blinding, almost mystic revelation. 'J'éprouvai un bonheur *divin*', he wrote, many years later, to his sister

Pauline Beyle. It was the discovery of *music* (the opera performed was Cimarosa's *Matrimonio segreto*, and Cimarosa, from that instant onward, was to rank for him as one of the sublimest artists of all time); but it was the discovery of much more—of a freedom, a release, a welling-up of unknown emotions, a *happiness* so wholly unsuspected in the desiccating atmosphere of Grenoble or amid the disenchantments of Paris, that henceforward he knew, as if by some inner prompting, that there was no life possible for him, save southward of the Alps.

In consequence, much of the story of Stendhal's life for the next forty years is the tale of his attempts to escape from the routine of his occupations and responsibilities in France, and to recapture the intoxication of this land of enchantment. This first visit—he soon abandoned his civilian clothes for the uniform of a second-lieutenant in the 6th Regiment of Dragoons—lasted some eighteen months. He visited Mantua, Bergamo, Verona; took part, not without distinction, in the battle at the crossing of the Mincio; and was later stationed at Bra, in the region of Alessandria. None the less, the true core of this early experience was the discovery of Milan. Here, he had a foretaste of that all-possessing love for the city which was to haunt him for so long, of the freedom and informality of its manners, of the magic of its women. On the one hand, *la Scala*; on the other, Angela Pietragrua, that majestic, raven-haired, generous and faithless creature who was to torment him almost to the verge of suicide. By the end of the first year, he was already, subconsciously at least, that *Arrigo Beyle, Milanese*, whom he describes with such lucidity and affection in the *Souvenirs d'Egotisme*. For all that, however, Beyle was suited to any life rather than that of the professional soldier. In November 1801, he asked for, and was granted, leave of absence from his regiment; and in fact it was to be ten years before he saw the skies of Italy again.

During the following decade, he tried his hand, with greater or lesser success, at commerce in Marseilles, at literature in Paris and at administration in Germany. Pierre Daru was still his superior in the Napoleonic service. At first, relations between the two cousins had been fairly strained; but after some years, Daru had learned how to get the best out of his somewhat unmanageable subordinate, and, in August 1811, as a mark of his satisfaction, he was prevailed upon to grant him two months leave. Thus it came about that, at eight o'clock on the morning of August 29th, Beyle managed to shake off the snivelling Angelina Bereyter, his mistress from the Italian Opera in Paris, and set forth in the stage coach for Milan.

As he drew near to the city, all the old fever of love was reawakened. Even 'une certaine odeur de fumier particulière à ses rues' could move him almost to tears—how much more, then, the visit which he was to pay, trembling with shyness, to Angela Pietragrua, last seen in 1801. But if Angela had not changed, Henri Beyle had: if she was still the same magnificent coquette, he was no longer quite the same blushing second-lieutenant, content to admire from afar. There were several skirmishes, 'une grande

bataille', and Angela was conquered . . . for a while. Yet the presence of such a romantic lover, to one of her temperament and inclinations, was decidedly an embarrassment; and she it was who, within a day or two of her 'defeat', persuaded him to leave Milan and set out upon a tour of Italy—Mantua, Florence, Rome, Naples, Ancona—of which he kept a diary, and of which not a few reminiscences have passed into *Rome, Naples and Florence*. All the while, however, his heart was in Milan; each stage of his journey was hurried and abbreviated, that he might return to Lombardy without delay; and so, by October 22nd, he was back again in the Albergo della Città—only to find that Angela had left some days earlier for Varese. Here he followed her, only to catch her in an evil temper, and to be violently snubbed for his pains. Disconsolate, he made his way back into Milan, and the remaining three weeks of his freedom (he had long overstayed his leave, besides committing other indiscretions which were not calculated to please Daru!) were spent in alternate quarrels and reconciliations—a series of upheavals which awoke in him an intensity of emotion of which he had never before suspected himself capable. Five-and-twenty years later, he still recalled these weeks as among the most tormented and yet the happiest of his life.

Upon his return to Paris, he had to face the anger of Daru, and there ensued a scene which still rankled as late as 1826. But the following months were destined to be so eventful that his immediate disgrace was forgotten. Once more abandoning the exasperatingly faithful Angelina Bereyter, he set off for Moscow with despatches, arrived in time to see the fire and the beginning of the retreat, survived the terrible road from Smolensk to Vilna and the passage of the Berēzina, and was no sooner back in Paris than he was off on a new mission, this time to Bautzen and Sagan. In 1813, there was precious little leisure allowed to a Napoleonic administrator; but in Sagan, finally, his health gave way, and in August of that same year, he was once again accorded leave—and once more took the highroad to Milan.

'I am destined once again', he wrote to Pauline, 'to see my beloved land of Italy. Italy is my true home. Not that I bear a disproportionate fondness for this object or for that; it is simply that the country as a whole *matches my temperament*.'

This third Italian journey was in many ways an echo of the second, two years earlier. The scenes with Angela were repeated; there were the same 'victories', the same jealousies, the same reconciliations. This time, however, it was to Monza that Angela escaped to avoid his importunities, while Beyle set foot for the first time on the soil of Venice. In the latter days of his leave, however, there came a calmer period, a few weeks of autumnal happiness which seem to centre about one particular event: for, on October 12th, Beyle and his mistress spent the evening at *la Scala*, and there, for the first time, he watched a ballet—*Prometeo*—by Salvatore Viganò. Henceforward, Viganò—'the Shakespeare of the ballet'—was to rank with Cimarosa and Canova among the greatest geniuses of the century—the very incarnation of *la mia cara Italia*.

On this occasion, Beyle was careful not to overstay his leave; for nothing in the world would he have quarrelled *now* with Pierre Daru, for he had hopes—promises even—of a permanent post in Italy, the ultimate goal of all his desires. But alas! the great collapse was already at hand. The allied armies were advancing upon Paris, and the Napoleonic epic was all but ended. And Beyle, an efficient, albeit a minor cog in the administrative machine, was gravely compromised, in the eyes of the Bourbon restoration, by his all-too-enthusiastic support of the previous régime. At one stroke, he lost his rank, his salary and all the benefits of his accumulated service; moreover, the very prospect of France under Louis XVIII and the 'Jesuits' he found too nauseating to be borne. Less than nine months, therefore, after his return to Paris, we find him cutting loose once and for all from poor Angelina Bereyter; and by August 10th, 1814, he was back again in Italy—not as a tourist this time, still less, as he had fondly hoped, as an administrator under Prince Eugène, but pitifully, as a *refugee*.

This, his fourth 'visit' to Milan, was to last the better part of seven years. He had nothing but the most inadequate private income to meet his needs; he was friendless and politically suspect, his health was still only partially restored. Moreover, his relationship with Angela was now more of a torture than a joy. The moments of reconciliation grew ever rarer; she sent him off successively to Genoa, to Leghorn, to Florence, to Venice and to Padua; but eventually her infidelities became so flagrant, that not even so willingly blind an idealist as Henri Beyle could deny himself the truth any longer. Towards the end of 1815, he broke with her for good, yet not without the cruellest suffering. 'C'était une catin', he wrote of Angela much later, 'mais une catin sublime.'

All in all, these first two years were years of misery; yet, for all that, Italy was still Italy; there was still music at *la Scala*, there were still paintings in the Brera; furthermore, to while away the time and to distract his thoughts, Beyle was beginning to write—no longer those ever-deferred, ideal comedies and tragedies which had for so long been destined (in his own mind) to win him immortality, but works of a more pedestrian nature: the *Lives of Haydn, Mozart and Metastasio* (cribbed largely from Carpani and various others), a *History of Painting in Italy*; and finally, towards 1816, a book simply about Italy, to meet the needs of that ever-growing stream of travellers now pouring south across the Alps. This plain 'travelogue' (yet how personal, how delightfully inaccurate, how tendentious, in a word, how *Stendhalian*!) was destined to be the primitive version of *Rome, Naples and Florence*, and it appeared in Paris in September, 1817.¹ On the surface, it was simply the factual account of a journey; but facts, for Henri Beyle—now for the first time appearing before the public as *M. de Stendhal, Officier de Cavalerie*

¹ *Rome, Naples et Florence en 1817*, par M. de Stendhal, officier de cavalerie. Paris (Delaunay), 1817. In-8°, 366 pp. The book sold well, and in fact represents Beyle's first success as an author. In October 1817, the French text was re-issued in London, with some minor alterations: *Rome, Naples et Florence en 1817, ou Esquisses sur l'état actuel de la société, des moeurs, des arts, de la littérature, etc., de ces villes célèbres*. Londres (Colburn), 1817. In-8°, pp. xii + 353.

—were never more than an excuse. Just as he had used his *History of Painting* to propound a *theory of beauty*; just as he was to use his *Life of Rossini* to suggest a *theory of music*; so likewise the factual background to *Rome, Naples and Florence* in 1817 was just so much necessary camouflage to disguise, or evidence to justify, a *theory of Italy*—a theory which is complex, involving love and art no less than history and politics, and which, in point of fact, is nothing less substantial than a far-reaching exploration of *la chasse au bonheur*.

Meanwhile, however, the grimmest days of his Italian exile were over. By July 1816 he had recovered from his infatuation for Angela—an infatuation so obsessive that Napoleon's return from Elba, and indeed all the campaign which ended in the disaster of Waterloo, seem to have left him indifferent—and gradually the circle of his friends was widening. In particular, Ludovico di Breme, from 1816 until his death in 1820 the recognised leader of intellectual life in Milan, had been curious to know this timid and somewhat unprepossessing refugee, whose reputation, despite his passion for anonymity, had been gradually infiltrating across the frontier; and, having met him, had introduced him to the whole of that carbonarist *élite* which gathered nightly at *la Scala*.

Napoleon, it must be remembered, had left his mark upon Italian politics, not merely by the administrative reforms which he had introduced to supersede the older, *laissez-faire* imperium of Austria, but above all by his promise, formulated soon after Marengo, of an independent, *united Italy*. With the return of Lombardy under Austrian dominion—a dominion which, at first, had not proved exceedingly repressive—a group of intellectuals had come rapidly to the fore, under the vague and perhaps misleading title of *carbonari*, whose primary object it was to bring about the longed-for unification of the whole Peninsula. To this group (whose organ was to be the periodical *il Conciliatore*) belonged, more or less actively, the poet Silvio Pellico, the philosopher Melchiorre Gioja, the critics Borsieri and Ermes Visconti, not to mention such minor figures as Carlo Guasco and Giuseppe Vismara.

It was the last of these new-found friends who, in the first weeks of 1818, introduced Beyle to one of the 'guardian angels' of the group, Mathilde Visconti-Dembowski, the Milanese wife of a dissolute and drunken Polish officer. Mathilde's marriage was desperately unhappy; she found consolation, however, partly in her unflagging political activity, partly in her sincere and lasting affection for the poet Ugo Foscolo. This meeting was the prelude to the greatest emotional crisis of Stendhal's life—'*la grande phrase musicale*', as he himself was to call it—which began on the 4th of March, 1818, and ended only with the death of 'Métilde' in 1825. If Italy was the incarnation of all that Henri Beyle loved, or ever desired to love, then 'Métilde' was the incarnation of Italy—of *Lombardy* in particular, with all that singular beauty 'tinged with melancholy' which Beyle had ever admired above all else in Lombard women.

But no sooner had Beyle grown aware of the depth and extent of his own love (beside which his fifteen-year-long passion for Angela Pietragrua

appeared now as a kind of adolescent infatuation) than he grew aware also that Mathilde was deliberately avoiding him. Here, once again, politics had intervened. Mathilde had a cousin, signora Traversi, who was hand-in-glove with the most reactionary elements in Milan, and who had directly provoked the assassination of Count Prina. Beyle, ever a 'liberal', had pointedly and publicly refused to be introduced to her. For such a patent insult, la Traversi had vowed him an undying hatred; and this hatred—or at least an echo of it—had been transmitted to Mathilde.

The remaining three years of Beyle's life in Milan were wholly overshadowed by this love he had for a woman who never once gave him the least sign of encouragement. Unlike Angela, Mathilde had not the minutest trace of the coquette in her character; she seems to have been serious almost to the verge of pedantry, and circumspect almost to the point of prudishness. Moreover, at grips with such a far-reaching storm of passion within himself, Beyle was once more overwhelmed with that frightening timidity and gaucheness which had ruined so many of his earlier love-affairs. His diaries and jottings of this period tell us part at least of this anguished and yet boundlessly happy episode in his life; yet he has left us no coherent portrait of 'Métilde' herself. Rather, if we are to understand her, we should turn to his heroines: for each in turn of these creatures who dominate his novels—Armance de Zohiloff, Mathilde de la Mole, Madame de Chasteller, Clélia Conti—owes something at least (if not her very existence) to the memory of 'la grande phrase musicale'.

The seven years in Italy, however, were now drawing to a close. The political situation had deteriorated rapidly. Abortive revolutions in Naples and Piedmont had disturbed the Austrian authorities in Lombardy; the *carbonari* were arrested and imprisoned or executed; di Breme was dead; Beyle himself was grown more than suspect to the government and the police, but the Austrians, rather than risk an international incident by deporting him, resorted to the ingenious scheme of spreading the rumour among the remaining 'liberals' of the city that Beyle was a French royalist *agent provocateur*, deliberately cultivating their acquaintance in order to betray them. Gradually, *salon* after *salon* began to be shut against him. For good measure, the police themselves began to make his life progressively more uncomfortable. At long last, in the summer of 1821, Beyle's situation became untenable; an object of suspicion to friends and enemies alike, he realised that all he loved and treasured in Milan was lost to him for good. On June 6th, he said farewell to Mathilde for the last time (he was never to see her again), and on the 13th, took the coach for Paris.

This date marks an essential turning-point in Beyle's life. The long period of formation was over at last; the period of creation was about to begin. Henceforward, his love for Italy, like his love for Mathilde, changes character. He was not yet done with the Peninsula; in 1823-4 (Lombardy being still barred against him) he spent some five months in Florence and Rome, and in 1830 he received the post he had so eagerly coveted some twenty years earlier—a consular appointment, first in Trieste, later in

Civitavecchia. But, although he was to keep it until the end of his life, it had come too late; and when it was his, he no longer really wanted it. For, in effect, the book of Italy was closed to him in 1821; and what new discoveries the country had still to offer were destined to come, no longer from the present, but rather from the remote past—from those countless histories of the Mediaeval Republics which he was soon to read and re-read with such childlike eagerness.

From his earliest youth, Beyle—like Proust—had been obsessed with the problem of *reliving the past*. For the first twenty years of the century, he had lived a life so full, so passionately occupied, that this problem had, to some extent, been pushed into the background; but, now that the present stood enveloped in a sudden emptiness, the past began to occupy more and more of his thoughts. This past—*his* past—must not be allowed to vanish; to be re-lived, it must be *re-created*; and so, out of Beyle the administrator, Beyle the exile, Beyle the lover, there begins slowly to emerge Stendhal the writer. Two things above all had most imperatively to be recovered, salvaged from the waste-land of 'remembered facts': 'Métilde' and Italy. At first, his mind began to work analytically: he dissected his own sensations (*De l'Amour*), dissected his reactions to literature (*Racine et Shakespeare*), dissected the music he had once heard and still remembered (*Vie de Rossini*). But dissection was no real substitute for creation. There was a whole world to be created—a world whose centre was Milan. By 1826, this half-remembered, half-imagined world of Italy was so vividly present within his soul, that he took down the old, now half-forgotten travelogue of nine years earlier, determined to resurrect it in a new shape. In a remarkably short space of time, he had discarded from it what now seemed ephemeral or unimportant, swelled it to twice its original size with material which had long lain in his notes or in his mind—and thus was born the present volume, still with its old but now misleading title, *Rome, Naples et Florence*.

No sooner was the manuscript off his table and away to the publisher, than he was deeply committed to *Armance*—the first work of purely imaginative fiction which he had attempted. Nor is this mere chance. The processes of analysis and memory were slowly yielding to the unifying force of imagination; and *Rome, Naples et Florence* is already the portrait of an *imaginary* rather than of a real Italy: it is a first sketch, a glimpse of that miraculous country, in the midst of which is set *la Chartreuse*. From Milan to Parma is but a step. In between, admittedly, there come the novels set in France: *Armance*, *le Rouge et le Noir*, *Lucien Leuwen*. In 1826, Stendhal had still much to learn about the *techniques* of imaginative creation; but little or nothing to add to what he wanted to write about. Successively, Mathilde was transformed, from novel to novel; successively, through the *Promenades dans Rome* and the *Chroniques Italiennes*, Italy was transformed likewise—all as a prelude to the greatest transformation of all, the *Charterhouse of Parma*. Dictated from start to finish in a spell of two-and-fifty days, the *Charterhouse* was the final culmination of a life not merely fully lived, but already fully relived, through art and imagination, until memory seemed more real,

more obsessive, than even the original experience itself. In the dream-fantasy of Parma, Italy and Mathilde—even Angela—are brought finally together, and the vision of an ideal land of beauty, where love and art alike are 'a promise of happiness'—the vision conceived prophetically in that flea-bitten opera-house in Ivrea thirty-nine years earlier—is given its perfect and eternal form.

* * *

So much is it necessary for the reader to know as a background to *Rome, Naples and Florence*. *Rome, Naples and Florence* is not a *factual* guide to Italy; it is an idealised *vision* of Italy by one of the most subtle and romantic spirits of all time. It is also, in its context (nor should the fact be overlooked or forgotten), a *pamphlet*—a political pamphlet written by an ardent, liberal-minded intellectual who had been both morally nauseated and physically victimised by the period of stupidity, meanness and reaction in which he lived. It is generally recognised that Stendhal, in *le Rouge et le Noir*, created the first great *political* novel of our epoch. But in this field as in others, much of the essential work of preparation had been done earlier. *Rome, Naples and Florence*, by the very fact that it is a work about Italy written by a Frenchman, is doubly political in its implications: it offers *positive* criticism of the actual state of affairs in Italy, and a positive solution to the evils which, from 1815 onwards, had afflicted the Peninsula; but it also suggests a *negative* criticism of the régime which held sway in France, by contrasting French society, as contemporaries knew it, with life as it was—or might be—lived in that idealised land beyond the Alps.

Stendhal's vision of Italy is far from simple. Italy represents a kind of Utopia (perhaps Maxime Leroy was not entirely wrong when he classed Stendhal among the 'Utopian socialists' of the nineteenth century), where aristocratic *sensibility* and plebeian *energy* contrive by some miracle to exist side by side, neither quality sapping nor devouring the other. It is a land of leisure, where love is fed by passion, yet still cultivated as an art (another Utopian contradiction); where, in fact, art and love are all but synonymous, being but different manifestations of the same dynamic force. It is a country of moral freedom, where the sham conventions of society are powerless against the natural ardour of men and women born without hypocrisy, and yet where men and women, despite the inhuman government under which they exist, still contrive to retain sufficient dignity to prevent their liberty ever degenerating into licence. It is a land of informality, and yet of natural grace and manners; of rational cynicism, and yet of decent respect towards the established superstitions; of an ignorant and vicious despotism, and yet (for such is the fertile nature of the Italian mind) of a despotism which itself breeds heroes out of slaves and conjures up painters, sculptors and musicians by the very restraint which it imposes upon all more direct and forceful means of expression. But above all, Italy, for Stendhal, is the homeland of Angela Pietragnua and of Mathilde Viscontini; and so, with all its defects, its vices, its preposterous absurdities and anachronisms, it is a land singled out by nature and blessed above all others; a land where 'the love of art and

the art of love' have been brought to a higher pitch of perfection than anywhere else upon the surface of the globe.

* * *

The present translation is based upon the critical edition by Daniel Muller (2 vols., Champion, 1919), which is included in the *Oeuvres Complètes de Stendhal*, published under the general editorship of Paul Arbet and Edouard Champion. Occasional verifications have been introduced from the text presented by the late Henri Martineau (*Le Divan*, 1927) and from other recent editions.

The primitive version of Stendhal's 'Journey', *Rome, Naples et Florence en 1817*, has previously appeared in English¹ although the translation has been out of print for well over a century, and is inaccurate into the bargain; the much fuller, and indeed almost completely different text of 1826² is now appearing in English for the first time. In France, it was customary for many years to add the discarded portions of the 1817 text as an appendix to that of 1826; but recent critical studies—notably by MM. Martineau, Bardèche and del Litto—have convincingly demonstrated that the 1817 edition is an important book in its own right, and consequently, that to present it thus in fragmentary form is to do it a very real disservice. I have confined myself, therefore, to indicating in the notes those passages which have survived from the earlier version.

All Stendhal's writings—not excluding the novels—are rich in references to contemporary events and personalities—so rich that, in order to avoid losing the original text altogether in a grotesque labyrinth of footnotes (Stendhal's and my own), I have preferred to compile an *Index* at the end, which gives a certain minimum of necessary information. Such few footnotes of my own as have seemed indispensable are signed (*Trans.*); all the others are Stendhal's own additions in the original French. However, since some of these footnotes were added in 1826, whereas others belong to the earlier edition, the date has been indicated in each case in square brackets. For the section at the end headed *Notes* (to which references are indicated by an asterisk * in the text), I am heavily indebted to Daniel Muller, and also to the important annotated edition of *Rome, Naples et Florence en 1817*, published in 1956 by Henri Martineau. I also gratefully acknowledge my indebtedness to Mr Philip McNair for his valuable suggestions in the field of Italian geography, history and politics, and to Mademoiselle Marie-Louise Thyss for her numerous and ingenious elucidations of Stendhal's somewhat idiosyncratic French.

RICHARD N. COE,

Leeds, May 1959

- 1 *Rome, Naples and Florence in 1817: sketches of the present state of Society, Manners, Arts, Literature, etc., in these celebrated cities*, by the Count de Stendhal. London (Colburn) 1818, pp. xii + 339.
- 2 Of the original 1817 edition, Stendhal preserved rather less than one third (107 pages out of 353). The 1826 edition, which is in the same format, has a total of 652 pages; consequently, just over five-sixths of the revised version is made up of new material.

PREFACE*

A LONDON bookseller has already done me the honour of printing a second edition* of this pamphlet. For, in all truth, it has no claim to be called a book. The Author freely confesses that he has given never so much as a second glance to the larger part of those notes, from which the first edition was taken. In those days I entertained a fierce aversion to any form of literary affectation, and I was stoutly resolved to make no concessions to the critics of the press merely in order to win some renown as a man of letters in Paris. Indeed, I never foresaw that I should take up my abode in this *Capital of the World* for longer than one month in every two years, and then, merely that I might observe what was newly come to light, whether in the theatre, or in the broader realm of manners. I was persuaded that an Author may in no way deserve the approbation of his readers, save inasmuch as he remains true to himself; and further, that he may never hope to win a reputation in Paris, save in so far as he should make it his chief concern *to be like others*. In a word, I was as arrogant as a man may be who has just known six full months of happiness.

In this third edition, it is my pleasure to place before the reader the contents of my *Journal* more or less in their entirety; for, in 1817, caution had obliged me to refrain from printing many passages, innocent enough and indeed trivial enough in all conscience, yet which might have brought unwelcome attentions upon certain persons in Italy, whom I hold dear to my heart. These motives for reticence no longer exist. In the space of seven years, what sweeping changes may overtake *Fashionable Society**—the only society which can afford pleasure to the enquiring mind!

What interest may there be sought today in a portrait of the land of Italy as it was in the year 1817? I have myself on not a few occasions replied with this self-same query to those obliging persons who would have persuaded me to print a new edition. 'Other travellers, without exception, are wont to confine their descriptions of Italy to the realm of the *inanimate*; their portraits concern only the monuments, the sites, the sublime manifestations of nature in that happy land. Whereas *you*', I have been told, 'prefer to trace, to the limits of your modest ability, the *manners* of the inhabitants and the *contours of Italian Society*—that aggregate of singular and ingrained preferences for love, for pleasure, for solitude, for plain speaking, and so forth, whence, even now, there may chance to spring a genius, a Canova or a Rossini. Whereas in England or in France, the burden of *affectation*, without which there is neither prospect of *success* nor hope of *esteem*, reduces all artists to the status of waxen *dolls*. The majority of French travellers who post towards Rome for the purpose of enjoying the beauties of Italy, and of affording themselves a year of pure enchantment, take the road homeward half-dead of boredom, without having addressed a word to so many as three women of fashion in the whole course of their excursion; and indeed, the happiest instant of their entire journey comes when they return at last to their favourite table at the *café Tortoni*.'

These notes were jotted down in 1817, nor have I altered so much as twenty lines of them. At that epoch, I was happy; and there is nothing in all the world to which I render such sincere homage as to *happiness*. I propose to tender no excuses to the public for making it the gift of an indifferent book. After these last two pages which I have written, even that reader who is least attuned to my own peculiar *nuances* of feeling must know full well what manner of book he is to expect. If it should prove boring, none will read it: it needs no metaphysical argument to show that in such a case it were as though it had never existed. There might be *imposture*, did

I but count a friend or two among that band of *literary critics* who wield the press. But never yet have I deserved the most meagre of reviews. Indeed, a certain bookseller, who has undertaken to dispose of a volume of mine entitled *de l'Amour*, writes to me the following letter, which I, being engaged in correcting the proofs of this very page before your eyes, have received at this very instant:

Paris, 3rd April 1824

Sir,

I could heartily wish that the moment were at hand, when I might submit to you an account of the profits that I hoped to reap from the sale of your volume *de l'Amour*; I begin to fear, however, that that day may never come; I have not yet managed to sell so many as forty copies of this book; indeed, I would be tempted to apply to your production a phrase which referred originally to Lefranc de Pompignan's *Sacred Poems*: 'Sacred they are indeed, for none will lay a hand on them.'

I remain, Sir, yours, etc.

F. MONGIE, senior,

BOOKSELLER*

Were all my 'productions' destined to remain 'sacred' (as M. Mongie so elegantly turns the phrase), this baleful circumstance would none the less, in *my* eyes, appear less humiliating than the obligation to crawl upon my hands and knees up to the editorial offices of *le Constitutionnel*, there to beg the favour of a review. I am well aware that he who follows these principles of mine runs little risk of covering himself with what passes in France for glory. But if ever I found myself in a mood to beg favours, I would rather set off post-haste for Rome, there to solicit the office of a *monsignore*, which is, if truth be told, the only one that I desire. Despite all that common gossip may allege—in speech and in print—against Italy, the individual who deliberately cultivates affectation is as rare a bird in

Roman or in Milanese society as the man who behaves with natural simplicity in Paris. 'But', cries the herd, 'in Rome it is not the practice to rail against religion!'—no more, indeed, than it is the custom for a man of breeding to utter coarse obscenities in a drawing-room.

You are persuaded that the Italian is a hypocrite through and through, for ever lying and dissembling; yet, if the truth were known, he is the most *natural* creature in the whole continent of Europe. *You* would have him the wiliest of schemers, a model of consummate prudence, a very Machiavelli incarnate; yet do but consider the trusting, childlike *naïveté* of those unhappy conspirators in Piedmont and in Naples.

MONTMORENCY, 30TH JULY 1824

ROME, NAPLES AND FLORENCE

BERLIN, 2nd September 1816. Four months' leave! I have just read the letter . . . my heart is thudding with the joy, the ecstasy of it! Twenty-six years old, and still such an impassioned ass! So I *shall* see the fair land of Italy. . . . But not a hint of all this emotional turmoil to His Excellency. The Eunuchs are unrelenting in the black rage of their hearts against the poor libertines. And even when I reach home again, I must steel myself against the prospect of two months' sullen, silent *displeasure*. Yet joy in the dream of the journey overrides all else; *and who knows where the world may be three weeks from now**?

ULM, 12th September. Utter emotional sterility. A wind from the North, which withers the promise of pleasure. The Black Forest—most aptly descriptive!—is melancholy and impressive. The sombre green of the fir-trees makes a spectacular contrast with the blinding whiteness of the snow. But the retreat from Moscow has left me curiously indifferent to the thrill of snow among the forests.

MUNICH, 15th September. This evening, M. le comte de *** introduced me to signora Catalani. I found the salon of the celebrated *prima donna* stuffed to bursting-point with ambassadors and half the big-wigs under heaven; the rainbow-glitter of ribbons and decorations was alone enough to set one's head in a whirl. His Majesty is indeed a very gallant gentleman. Yesterday being Sunday, signora Catalani, who is a desperately pious creature, betook herself to the Chapel Royal, and sat

herself down most unblushingly in the minute private gallery exclusively reserved for the King's daughters. A court chamberlain, who, scared well out of his wits by the audacity of the thing, had attempted to advise her of the error of her ways, was repulsed with heavy losses. *She* (so she claimed), being honoured with the devotion of innumerable *Crowned Heads*, was fully entitled to sit . . . *etc.*, *etc.* His Majesty King Maximilian accepted the situation with all the gallantry of a man who has spent twenty years of his life a Colonel in the honourable service of France. In many another petty principality in the land, where court etiquette is the whip and scourge of society, a *faux pas* of such calamitous magnitude might well have led signora Catalani straight into the common gaol*!

MILAN, 24th September. It was seven o'clock in the evening when I arrived; I was limp with exhaustion; but I dragged myself straight off to *la Scala* . . . and there, at one stroke, lay all the justification of my journey. My senses were so utterly weary that they were beyond the furthest reaches of pleasure. Yet all the fantasy that the most exotic intricacy of an oriental imagination may evolve, all that is most baroque and most bizarre, all that is most sumptuous in architectural devising, all that can be made to live and breathe through the soft brilliance of draperies, all that can be coaxed into reality through the symbolism of characters who have not merely the costume, but the very faces and gestures of their make-belief and alien lands . . . all this and more have I seen tonight.

25th September. No time wasted: another visit to the finest opera-house in the world; another performance of *la Testa di Bronzo*. I had time now to give full rein to my admiration. The scene is set in Hungary; never was there a Prince in that country prouder or more imperious, more generous or more warlike than Galli. He is one of the finest actors I have ever met with, and he possesses the noblest bass voice that I have

ever heard; the very corridors of this gigantic theatre are set humming with the echoes of it.¹

And what a masterly handling of colour in the distribution of costume! It was as though I beheld, constantly evolving before my eyes, a series of most exquisite paintings by Paolo Veronese. There stood Galli, a Prince of Hungary in the national uniform of a hussar, with all its traditional brilliance of red, white and gold; and beside him his Chancellor of State, clad from head to foot wholly in black velvet, having no hint of glitter or ornament about him, save the insignia of his Order; while the Prince's ward (the entrancing mademoiselle Fabre) flaunted a cape of sky-blue and silver, with a white plume flown bravely in her shako. The whole stage of *la Scala* is afire with wealth and magnificence; the crowd of singers and actors rarely numbers less than a hundred at any given moment; and one and all are costumed with a splendour which, in France, would be reserved most severely for the star performers. One of the more recent ballets given on the stage here required one hundred and eighty-five specially-designed costumes of velvet or satin. The production expenses are immense. *La Scala* is the focal point of the entire city; it is the universal *salon*, the hub of society, which is here, and here *only*; not one open house in the whole of the town. *Rendez-vous at la Scala*—such is the accepted convention for all manner of business. The first experience is literally intoxicating. I am in a feverish daze as I write this.

26th September. I have recaptured the summer; this is the most stirring of all seasons in the fair land of Italy. There is a sort of drunkenness in my soul. I drove out to Desio*, a charming landscape garden ten miles north of Milan, at the foot of the Alps.

And now I am just back from *la Scala*. Dear God! My enthusiasm is still screwed to the same pitch as before! I called

¹ It is scarcely likely that words which may have been true of a voice in 1816 should still hold good a decade or so later [1826].

la Scala the finest opera-house in the world, because no other on earth can conjure up so much pure pleasure through the medium of music. There is not a single chandelier in the whole of the auditorium; all the illumination there is comes from the fan of light reflected from the stage. Imagination itself can conceive of nothing more grandiose, more magnificent, more impressive or more original than the *décor*, with its profoundly architectural rhythm. During this evening's performance alone there were eleven changes of scenery. Henceforward and for evermore, I am doomed to contemplate our own theatres with unalleviated disgust; this is the real price and penalty of journeying to Italy.

A box in the third tier costs me the sum of one *sequin* for each evening, on the understanding that I shall continue to reserve it for the entire duration of my stay. In spite of the almost total darkness in the auditorium, I managed perfectly well to pick out different people as they made their way into the pit. It is quite customary to give and acknowledge greetings from box to box across the theatre; I have a footing now in seven or eight different boxes, in each of which there may be five or six persons, and conversation firmly established, as in a *salon*. The tone of society is utterly *natural*, gay without being boisterous, and ruthlessly stripped of *gravity*.

In music, there is only one device for the measuring of beauty: a thermometer to record the fever-heat enchantment of the fire within our souls; whereas in painting, I may stand ice-cold and unmoved before a canvas by Guido Reni* and pronounce: *This is superlatively beautiful*.

27th September. A Duke of Hungary (the librettist *had* to make it a Duke, for, here in Milan, the police-censorship would never tolerate a *King* upon the stage, were there the remotest chance of preventing it—I might quote some curious instances); a Duke, then, let it be; a Duke of Pressburg, in love with his own ward; and she, meanwhile, secretly married to a young

officer (played by Bonoldi), who chances to be a *protégé* of the Chancellor of the Realm. This young officer has never known his parents; in fact, however, he is an illegitimate son of the Duke himself, and it is the Chancellor's ambition to engineer a public recognition. At the first hint which reaches him that his sovereign has designs upon his wife, the noble youth, abandoning his garrison, rides headlong to appeal to his protector, who, in sudden alarm, conceals him in a secret chamber underneath the Castle. This underground hiding-place has but one issue, whose access lies hidden in the pedestal of a statue which decorates the great hall of the Castle—a statue made in the likeness of a brazen head. This head, with all the signal-code required to operate the secret door, gives rise to the most rare and romanesque imbroglio . . . as in the *finale* of Act I when (the Duke being now at the very instant of leading his ward towards the altar-steps), the scene begins with a series of mighty thumpings delivered by a chicken-hearted lackey interred by mischance in the cellarage, and banging at the pedestal which holds the head in a desperate appeal for exhumation.

At long last, the Chancellor reveals to the Duke the secret of the young hero's birth; but he, meanwhile, has been pursued into the mountains as a deserter, captured and condemned to death. At the very climax of joy, as the sovereign exults in his new-discovered fatherhood, there come the echoes of a firing-squad: the sentence has been carried out. The quartet which opens with this sinister rattle of rifle-fire, the sudden metamorphosis of comedy into tragedy—all this would be counted a triumph, even if the score had borne the signature of a Mozart; judge then of the achievement, when it is that of a beginner at his first attempt! Signor Solliva, who is a pupil of the Milan *Conservatoire*, founded by Prince Eugène, is twenty-five years old. His music is more assured, more intense and more dramatic than any that I have heard for years. Never for an instant does his invention slacken. Is he a genius . . . or simply

an expert *plagiarist*? In recent months, Milan has seen two if not three Mozart operas in rapid succession, for Mozart is just beginning to find an audience south of the Alps; and Solliva's music is a perpetual reminiscence of Mozart. Is it a brilliant *pastiche*? Or is it truly a work of genius?

28th September. It is genius* ! There is a warmth about the music, an inward dramatic ferment, a stamp of assurance about each and every twist of style, that most plainly do not stem from Mozart. But Solliva is young still; dazed by the intensity of his own admiration for Mozart, he has learned to speak with the self-same accents of his hero. If Cimarosa were still the idol of his generation, he would have been heard to echo the voice of Cimarosa.

Dugazon used to tell me, when I still lived in Paris, that every new aspirant who joined his drama class* was a little would-be Talma. It used to take six months to strip away the borrowed plumes and to discover whether there was any genuine core of individuality underneath.

Among painters, the most accomplished by far in the portrayal of *dynamic activity* in his subjects is Tintoretto. Similarly, Solliva is unrivalled in the portrayal of dramatic tension. There is very little straightforward melody in his work. Bonoldi's *aria* in the first act is a failure. Where Solliva comes into his own is in passages of a very different character—in the *ensembles*, of course, but also in certain sections of accompanied recitative, which provide the ideal medium for psychological analysis. No art of description can convey the impact of Galli's entry in Act I, when he appears immersed in heated argument with his Chancellor. Such is the profusion of luxuriance that the eyes are dazzled; such is the power of sound, so virile in mood and yet so natural in expression, that the ear is overwhelmed; such is the total effect that the soul is swept irresistibly away by the action unfolding before it: this is indeed *sublime*. The finest tragedies in the world are dead and dreary

by comparison. Solliiva, like Correggio, understands the value of *density*; his music never flags for a second; if a thematic development contains no element of surprise, it will be ruthlessly abridged*; ideas are condensed and massed into compactness; and the eventual outcome is as fine as a symphony by Haydn in his most dynamic vein.

1st October. I have just learnt that *la Testa di Bronzo* is based upon a French melodrama. In Paris, it was a dismal failure; in Milan—thanks to the music—a triumph, a masterpiece; for the music brings depth and delicacy to the raw material of emotion. ‘Yet how is it’, I enquired of signor Porta, ‘how is it that no *Italian* librettist seems capable of inventing the sort of tale, the rich proliferation of dramatic incident, which opera demands?’

‘In Italy’, came the answer, ‘all thought is dangerous, and writing the epitome of indiscretion. Today is the first of October; yet did you notice the wind?—how soft, how sweetly sensuous, how languidly pervasive of the air. Would you have us risk a threat of exile among the snows of Munich, the icy reaches of Berlin, amidst a race of sad, uncivil folk who dream of nothing but the insignia of their orders and the sixteen quarterings upon their coat-of-arms? Our climate is the fairest jewel in all our heritage.’

And so Italy can hold no hope for literature until she shall first have won herself a constitutional government, with an Upper and a Lower House*; until the time of such an event, all culture is but a sham, all literature academic pedantry. In such a boundless desert of universal commonplaceness a true genius may yet find scope; but it is the fate of an *Alfieri* to work blindly in the dark; he must despair of any guidance from a *real* public. Free men who loathe oppression will laud him to the skies, while parasites who live by tyranny will pelt his name with mud and execration. And yet such is the degree of idleness, ignorance and hedonism among the younger generation of

Italians, that fully a century must certainly elapse before Italy shall have earned her constitution. Napoleon had set her on the right road, perhaps even without realising whither it led. He had already revived the tradition of individual courage among the peoples of Lombardy and the Romagna. The battle of Raab, in 1809, was won by Italians.

Such weary subjects are better left alone; instead, let us rather talk music. For here, south of the Alps, music is the only art which still retains a hold on life. With the exception of one solitary genius, the artists and the sculptors of Italy are of the same persuasion as the artists and the sculptors of Paris or London: honest folk who think in terms of *cash*. Whereas music still nourishes a belated spark of that creative fire which has burned unbroken from century to century, feeding the successive inspirations of a Dante or a Raphael; first poetry, then painting, then finally the music of a Pergolesi or a Cimarosa. In the beginning of things, this divine spark was first touched off by *liberty* and by the heroic cast of life which held sway under the mediaeval republics. In music, there are two paths which lead alike to the ultimate goal, two dissimilar styles which give promise of a similar delight—the way of Haydn and the way of Cimarosa: *harmony*, with its transcendent beauty, *melody* with its enchantment of delight. The style of Cimarosa is ideally suited to the peoples of the South, and defies the plodding mimicry of fools. It was towards the year 1780 that melody scaled the loftiest heights of glory; but ever since, the character of music has undergone a gradual transformation; harmony has usurped the throne, while melody wanes plaintively away. Painting is dead and buried. In sculpture, destiny has conjured up a Canova, a genius born to pierce the crust of mediocrity by the sheer power of vegetative growth that the soul of man possesses beneath these cloudless skies; yet Canova, like Alfieri, is a freak; he has no peers and no posterity; and all in all, sculpture is likewise as dead in Italy as the art of Correggio and his generation. Engraving

still flourishes well enough; but then, engraving is scarcely more than a trade for artisans.

Music alone still keeps a hold on life in Italy; and the only sensible *activity*, in all this fair land, is the art of *love*; no other pleasure of the soul may thrive unhindered, and melancholy frustration is the sole reward of a social conscience. Friendship is smothered by mistrust; but in compensation, *love* under such skies is a pure delight; no other land knows aught but the palest *imitation*.

I have just come away from a box at the opera, where I was introduced to a tall and handsomely-proportioned woman, whose age, at a guess, would be about thirty-two. She is still beautiful, with that rare style of beauty which is never met with north of the Alps. All about her bears the stamp of great wealth and luxury, yet her whole being radiates an aura of the profoundest melancholy. As I was leaving the box, a mutual friend who had brought us together addressed me, saying: 'I must tell you a story'.

There is nothing rarer, here in Milan, than to fall in with an Italian eager to embark upon a narrative with none for audience but another of his own sex. The effort is usually reserved for the company of some more tender feminine acquaintance, or at best, for an occasion when the narrator is well established in the reassuring luxury of a *poltrona* (easy-chair). The tale my new friend told me was enriched with a wealth of picturesque circumstance, more often than not described in gesture; I pass it on in an abridged version.

'Some sixteen years since, a man of great estate, by name Zilietti, a banker from Milan, arrived one evening in Brescia. His first act was to visit the theatre; and there, in a box, his attention was captured by the striking features and the extreme youth of an unknown woman. Now Zilietti was forty years old, and had recently been amassing wealth to the tune of millions; indeed, one might have suspected that he had no care in all the world save money. Moreover, his journey to Brescia

concerned some business matter, whose successful issue depended upon a prompt return to Milan. In an instant, every thought of money had flown from his head. With some difficulty, he managed to find an instant to whisper a word or two in the young enchantress' ear. You know her, of course: her name is Gina, and she was the wife of a man of noble birth and high fortune. In the end, Zilietti succeeded in persuading her to elope with him. And for sixteen years now he has adored her; yet, for that her husband is still alive, he has never been able to make her his wife.

'Six months ago, Gina's lover fell ill—for you must know that for some two years now, she has taken herself a lover, the poet Malaspina*—that excessively handsome fellow whom you met recently in the *salon* of la Bibin Catena. Zilietti, whose love is not a whit diminished since that first encounter, was desperately jealous. Every instant of his time which was not spent among his ledgers was passed with Gina. She meanwhile, distracted with the knowledge that her lover lay in danger of his life, yet well aware that every servant about her person was salaried with gold to spy and straightway report upon her every step, ordered her coachman to set her down by the Cathedral porch; and thence, making her way secretly through the crypts and passages beneath the nave, she emerged upon the further side, where the Archbishop has his residence, found the shop of an old-clothes'-merchant, and equipped herself with male attire and a set of ropes. Not knowing how else to reach home safely with her purchases, she bundled the garments out of sight beneath the folds of her own dress, and regained her carriage without further incident. No sooner was she inside her own front door than she asserted that she felt unwell, and locked herself alone in the privacy of her bedroom. At the first hour after midnight, having knotted her ropes into the rough semblance of a ladder, she fastened one end of it to her balcony and clambered silently down into the street. Her apartment, incidentally, was a *piano nobile* (first floor) at some considerable

distance from the ground. At half past one in the morning, disguised as a man, she reached her lover's bedside. Malaspina was in the seventh heaven of delight; if he had felt sorrow at the oncoming of death, it was only because he had despaired of a last glimpse of his beloved. "Yet come no more, sweet Gina", said he, when at length, towards three in the morning, she found the courage to tear herself from his side. "The doorkeeper of this house is in the pay and service of Zilietti; I am poor, nor are you richer than I am; yet wealth and luxury are woven into the pattern of your life, and I should die in despair if I should know myself the occasion of a rift between yourself and Zilietti."

'Gina tore herself out of his arms. Yet at two o'clock in the morning of the day following, there came a tapping at the window of Malaspina's apartment, which, like Gina's, was situated on the first floor, and looked out upon one of those great stone balconies which are so frequent in Italy. It was Gina, who, having climbed out of her own window with the aid of a rope-ladder, had then hoisted herself up to that of her lover by the same means. Yet when she found him, he was lost in a delirium, and could say no word but her name, nor speak of anything, save of his passion for her. And for thirteen nights without respite the same expedition took place, until at length Malaspina was well out of danger.'

To the good ladies of Paris, no adventure imaginable could bear a stronger taint of absurdity; and I, for being rash enough to retail such madcap escapades, am now well placed to receive *my* portion of the ridicule. I offer no moral justification for such manners; nevertheless, my soul is stirred within me and moved to exaltation. Tomorrow, when I meet Gina anew, I shall be compelled to treat her with the deepest reverence; there will be a turmoil in my heart as though I were once again but a callow lad of twenty. And *that* is an experience which I no longer enjoy in Paris.

Had I but dared, I could dearly have embraced the acquaint-

tance who told me this tale. I made him spin it out an hour or more in the telling. How can I check an impulse of deep affection towards him?

2nd October. Solliva is a meagre little fellow with all the stunted and unprepossessing appearance of *genius*. I am taking grave risks with my reputation by such unguarded assertions based on a first work; it would be wiser to wait for the second. If the Mozartian influence proliferates at the expense of *inward dramatic life*, then we must prepare to face the inevitable conclusion: here was yet another composer (and they are all too common in the field of music) whose talent ran to *one* opera only. Two operas, or maybe three—that is the best we may look for from our young hopefuls; after which there is nothing but repetition in a worked-out vein: look at Berton in France.

Galli, who is thirty years old and uncommonly handsome, is unquestionably the pillar and strength of *la Testa di Bronzo*. Some critics have preferred Remorini who, in the part of the Chancellor, is likewise a first-class bass with an extremely flexible voice, trained to a degree which is rarely met with among basses; yet, all in all, it is nothing more than a *mechanical instrument*, perfect of its kind, yet monotonous, with scarcely a hint of the human heart which inspires it. There is one little passage in this opera, in all not more than twenty bars in length:

O fortunato istante!

which has been universally acknowledged. It is a cry welling up from the heart; yet the composer has somehow caught the authentic echo of nature, and the audience set no bounds to the enthusiasm of its applause.

Mademoiselle Fabre, a young French singer born in Milan, actually within the walls of the Royal Palace, and brought up as a *protégée* of the vice-reine, possesses an extraordinarily fine voice, whose quality has improved notably since she took to living under the same roof as Velluti, the celebrated male soprano. Her performance is utterly bewitching in certain

passages of intense emotion; yet she would be heard to still greater advantage in a smaller theatre. In her private life, rumour would have it that she is in love with Love. Personally, I have no doubts whatsoever on the matter, ever since I watched her in Act II of *la Testa*, singing

Stringerlo al petto . . .

in the scene where she suddenly discovers that her husband, whose death she had heard in the echoes of the firing squad, is in fact still safe and sound. One of the Chancellor's most trusted agents had arranged for the soldiers to be issued with blank cartridges. The whole scene is both melodramatic and moving; and at this evening's performance, the entire audience was held in rapt attention.¹ Yet on other occasions, when Mademoiselle Fabre is inattentive or over-tired, then there is nothing drearier; such talents as she still possesses would bring her high repute in a harem, but hardly elsewhere. She is twenty years old, and even on her off days I find her infinitely preferable to such soulless songstresses as mademoiselle Cinti, for instance.

Bassi is superb: nothing frigid or mechanical *there*! What a supreme *buffo*, had God but favoured him with the gift of a voice! What ardour and energy in a spirit steeped to the last degree in the essential reality of his part! For forty nights on end, never missing an evening, he has performed in this *Testa di Bronzo*; yet never a glance into the audience; from first to last he *is* the part he plays—the cowardly yet mawkish lackey of the Duke of Hungary. In France, any man of such intelligence (Bassi also writes attractive little comedies of his own) who took his acting so seriously, and let his part absorb him so completely, even when there was no one there to listen, must surely dread to seem absurd. I propounded this objection to

¹ The widow of Marshal Ney* was in the theatre on this occasion [1817]. Just before the moment when the crash of rifle-fire is heard from the platoon which is carrying out the sentence, friends managed to lead her away from the audience [1826].

him this very evening, and this was his answer: 'I act well because it pleases *me* to do so. My interpretation is modelled upon a certain cringing lackey of my own imagination. When first I came to play the part, I could *visualise* this creature. Now, as soon as I step into the footlights, I *am* this same sneaking footman whom once I only *saw*, and this gives me intense pleasure. If I were to watch the audience, I should be bored to tears; and in all probability, my mind would go blank. And besides, even with all the voice I can muster, there is not much to boast of; if it were not redeemed by competent acting, what would there be left?'

Perfect tonal quality in the voice, like perfect harmony in a woman's features, is only achieved at the price of a frigid temperament.

By a kind of instinctive reflex, which I observed tonight in the reactions of a German acquaintance, Baron Koenigsfeld, such characters as Bassi, who are entirely the creatures of their own emotions, produce an incontestable *shock* upon a certain category of not particularly intelligent aristocrats: lofty breeding prefers a more *calculated* talent; primitive *inspiration* seems coarse and overdone. Only yesterday, this same punctilious nobleman stormed himself blue in the face at a waiter in the restaurant for having mis-spelt his aristocratic surname upon his place-card.

3rd October. The orchestra at *la Scala*, for all its exquisite interpretation of *legato* passages, is somewhat lacking in *brio* in the more powerful sections of the score. There is a suspicion of timidity in the way the instruments attack the note.

The orchestra at the *Théâtre Favart* suffers from a contrary distemper, being mainly concerned to make life as awkward as possible for the singer, and to create as much noise as it can. In the *ideal* orchestra, the string section would be French; the wind, German; and the rest, Italian—including the conductor.

At *la Scala*, this post, where co-operation with the singers

is so essential, is held by the celebrated Alessandro Rolla, who had to be requested by the police to give up performing on the viola, on account of the number of nervous breakdowns produced in the female portion of the audience.

For a Frenchman newly-arrived in Milan, the following comparison might prove instructive: in the field of music, Molière is represented by Cimarosa, and Corneille by Mozart, while Mayr, Winter, etc., are the equivalents of Marmontel and company. The prose of La Fontaine, with all its limpid innocence (as in *les Amours de Psyché*), is paralleled in music by Paisiello.

4th October. Today, I went to see the frescoes by Luini at Saronno, which are most moving; and I visited the Charterhouse at Carignano, with more frescoes, this time by Daniele Crespi, a most remarkable painter who had modelled his vision upon the brothers Carracci, and his sensibility upon Correggio. I caught a glimpse of Castelazzo; but I was extremely disappointed with a certain castle at Montebello, which owes its fame to the fact that Napoleon stayed there in 1797. Acting in accordance with the well-worn precept: *major e longinquo reverentia*, from that time forward Bonaparte steadily avoided taking up his residence in cities, where he would have been too easily accessible. By contrast, Leinate, which is a garden full of architecture and belonging to Antonio Litta, a Duke of the Empire, I found delightful. Litta is one of the few members of the Napoleonic court who have not played turncoat since 1814, and he has held out his ground most stoutly against the *Tedeschi*. It is worth noting, moreover, that Napoleon promoted him to the rank of High Chamberlain *without his asking*. Antonio Litta has written a book, printed in one single edition comprising one solitary copy, which he has every intention of consigning to the flames before his death. He is said to enjoy an income of some seven or eight hundred

thousand *livres* a year. In one of the avenues of Leinate, I caught a distant glimpse of the wife of his nephew, *il duchino*; she is numbered among the dozen loveliest women of Milan. She reminded me of some old Spanish portrait, with her air of fine disdain. It is exceedingly unwise to go walking alone in the gardens of Leinate; the park is mined with concealed spouts and fountains*, expressly fashioned to produce a fine soaking for the unwary visitor. As soon as I placed my foot upon the lowest step of a certain staircase, no fewer than six jets of water were set off in a great spurt between my legs.

It was Italy that provided the model and inspiration for French architects in the days of Louis XIV, and gave them a taste for gardens like those of Versailles and the Tuileries, where architecture and trees merge to form an essential unity.

In the *Gergnetto*, a villa belonging to His Most Militant Piety Giacomo Mellerio, I found some sculpture by Canova. I paid another visit to Desio, a landscape-garden in the plain English style situated to the north of Milan, which still seems the finest of them all. It affords a clear view of the mountains, quite close, and of the *Rezegon di Lek**. Here, the air is healthier and more bracing than in Milan. Napoleon had ordered the rice-fields and the *marciti* meadows (which are under perpetual irrigation, and yield eight crops a year) to be removed five miles beyond the confines of Milan. Unwisely, however, he allowed the peasants a fixed term of delay in order to change to a new type of cultivation. The advantages of rice as a staple crop in this part of the country are immense; consequently, the landowners found ways and means to bribe the vigilance of the police; and now, westward of Milan, towards the Porta Vercelli, I discovered rice-fields within a cannon-shot of the town itself. As for robbers on the highway, scarcely a night passes without meeting a band or two within gunshot-range. The police here bears a remarkable resemblance to that of Paris: most of its energies are dissipated in politics, and (to show no ill-feeling) it carries out the most barbarous pruning-

operations on all the trees planted by Napoleon, thereby claiming the immemorial *right of faggots*.

But in the last resort, here in Italy, even the *agents provocateurs* are Italians, and share Italian tastes; and so this police, for all its corruption, has driven the citizens of Milan to work wonders for the improvement of their city. For instance, in the fiercest of downpours, the traveller may walk close beneath the walls of the houses without getting drenched. Tin-plate guttering carries the spill of water from the roofs directly into the main drain which runs beneath the level of every street; and as the cornices jut out from the wall to some considerable distance, and the balconies likewise, there is comparative shelter to be found in keeping close to the houses, even when the rain is at its heaviest.

The reader would deem me an enthusiastic ass, were I simple-minded enough to set down word for word all that I wrote on the 4th of October 1816, on the road home from Desio. This delightful villa, incidentally, belongs to the *marchese* Cusani, who, under the Napoleonic *régime*, once sought to outrival the luxury of Antonio Litta.

Galli has a bad cold. *La Scala* has revived *Elena*, an opera by Mayr, which had been running before the *première* of *la Testa di Bronzo*. Dear God, how *dull* it seems!

Yet what wild enthusiasm still survived to greet the *sextet** in Act II! This is the kind of music I used to hear so often in Bohemia: a *nocturne*, the very quintessence of melancholy, sweet and deeply moving. There is genius in such a passage; old Mayr must have saved it up from the days of his youth, or else pilfered it where he chanced to light upon it. Alone, this passage rescued the entire opera from disaster. Here you have the hall-mark of a nation born with an innate feeling for *beauty*: a whole opera, two hours long, saved from the depths by one single passage of scarce six minutes' duration; the crowds come flocking in from fifty miles' radius just to hear this one sextet sung by Mlle Fabre, by Remorini, Bassi,

Bonoldi, etc.; and night after night for forty performances on end, these same six minutes will win forgiveness for an hour or more of boredom. There is nothing *shocking* in the rest of the opera; there is merely *nothing*. . . . And so, from the two hundred miniature *salons* which go by the name of boxes, each with its curtain-draped window giving a view across the vastness of the auditorium, there arises a lively buzz of conversation. A box costs eighty *sequins*; only six years ago, during the Golden Age of Italy (the Napoleonic *régime*, 1805-1814), the same box would have cost two hundred or two hundred and fifty. In France, Napoleon brought back the Jesuits, and left the land in mourning for that liberty which, in the year 1800, she had still enjoyed; in Italy, he appeared as the scourge of corruption and the protector of true merit. Given twenty years' experience of rational despotism under so great a man, the people of Italy might perhaps have grown to deserve the high honour of bicameral government.

There are eight or ten boxes now, where I know I shall be made welcome; and I know of nothing more charming, more sympathetic, more truly and unreservedly admirable than the manners and customs of society in Milan. Nothing could be further removed from the life that is lived in England; never a hint of a withered heart or a countenance of despair. As a general rule, every woman is escorted by her lover; mild sallies of wit there may be, even lively arguments and wild bursts of laughter; but solemnity and self-importance have been banished from the earth. At the root of the matter lies the fact that Milan is a republic goaded into perpetual irritation by the presence of three regiments of Teutons, and compelled to furnish three millions in levies to the Emperor of Austria. Our own especial air of standing on our dignity (which the Italians call *sostenuto*), our noble art of *pretentiousness*, without which no man may be judged worthy of his salt, would appear in Italy the *nec plus ultra* of intolerable weariness. Once your spirit has grasped the fascination of this happy-go-lucky

existence in Milanese society, there is no escaping from its spell. Many a Frenchman of the great Napoleonic generation came hither to embrace those fetters which he wore about him until his dying day.

Of all the cities in Europe, none has better-planned streets*, nor finer courtyards behind the façades of its houses, than Milan. These courtyards are square, and, as was the fashion in ancient Greece, are surrounded by a portico supported by granite columns of extraordinary beauty. In all Milan there must be some twenty thousand granite columns; the stone is quarried in Baveno, beside Lake Maggiore, and is ferried down towards the city along the famous canal which links the Adda to the Ticino. Leonardo da Vinci was concerned with the construction of this canal in 1496, when we in France, as indeed throughout the North, were as yet no better than uncouth barbarians.

Only two nights ago, the owner of one of these proud mansions, finding himself unable to sleep, was strolling up and down beneath the porticos at five o'clock in the morning, while the dawn lay hidden in a steady fall of warm rain. All at once his eye was caught by a figure emerging from a side entrance on the ground floor, and he recognised one of his acquaintances, who was, as it chanced, an exceedingly handsome young man. Putting two and two together, he quickly concluded that the stranger had passed the night unbidden beneath his roof. Knowing that the young man had a genuine interest in agriculture, and using the rain as a pretext for conversation, the husband, without interrupting his sheltered stroll beneath the portico, kept his rival for two whole hours standing there in the downpour while he plied him with endless questions on farms and farming. Not until eight o'clock had struck, and the rain showing no signs of abating, did the husband most gallantly take leave of his acquaintance and return within the house.

The good people of Milan combine two rarely compatible

qualities which I have never before observed so closely united in any national character: shrewdness and generosity. In argument, the Milanese is as sparing of words as Tacitus; in sharp contrast to his English opposite, at least half the sense of his discourse is conveyed by glance and gesture; yet as soon as he comes to set pen to paper, he succumbs in an instant to the glamour of a fine flow of Tuscan rhetoric, and spins words faster than Cicero.

Signora Catalani is come to town with the promise of four recitals. The tickets are to cost ten francs each, and the whole of Milan holds up its hands in horror. It is scarcely credible. I have seen an entire box-full of people, one and all blessed with a fortune of eighty or a hundred thousand *livres* a year, and quite prepared, should the need arise, to lay out thrice that sum on the construction of a *palazzo*, object furiously to this 'extravagance' of ten francs. In Milan, to all intents and purposes, theatre-going costs nothing. The price of a seat at *la Scala*, on a regular subscription, is precisely six-and-thirty *centimes*. For this absurd sum, the spectator may sit through the first act of an opera (a full hour's entertainment in itself: the whole performance is timed to begin at half-past seven in winter; in summer, at half-past eight), followed by a full-length serious ballet, lasting an hour and a half; after the ballet comes the second act of the opera, say three-quarters of an hour; and the evening finally closes with a short comic ballet, usually exquisite, which is designed to see you off the premises in a gale of laughter towards half-past twelve or one o'clock in the morning. The purchase of an ordinary ticket (two francs for occasional visitors, thirty-six *centimes* for regular subscribers) entitles you to a seat in the pit, which is equipped with benches comfortably upholstered and with a good back to lean against. The pit can seat about nine hundred persons. If you happen to enjoy the privilege of a box, it is normal to arrive there early so as to receive visitors. A box at *la Scala* is treated as freehold property, like a house, and may change hands for as much as twenty-five

thousand francs. The Government grants an annual subsidy of two hundred thousand francs to the *impresario*, who exercises, in addition, the right of leasehold over all the boxes in the fifth and sixth tiers, bringing in a further hundred thousand francs. The balance of his assets is made up from the sale of tickets. Under the Napoleonic *régime*, the management also controlled a Casino, and the profits from the bank, to the tune of some six hundred thousand francs a year, made possible the engagement of front-rank dancers and singers. *La Scala* can seat an audience of some three thousand five hundred persons; but the pit is rarely more than half full, which is one of its greatest advantages*.

Half-way through the evening, it is the normal duty of the escorting gallant to regale his mistress with ices, which are served in the box. There is invariably some wager afoot, and the stake is always the same: *sorbets*, or water-ices. These *sorbets* are divine; they may be of three kinds, *gelati*, *crepè* and *pezzi duri*; and no one should fail to make so rewarding an acquaintance. I am still undecided which of the three species is the most exquisite; and so, every evening, I resort to experiment.

6th October. And so, at last—after so many fanfares—the much-heralded recital by signora Catalani *has* eventually taken place*. It was held in the *Conservatoire*, and the hall was half-empty. I doubt whether there were more than four hundred people in the audience, all in all. The musical taste of the Milanese is instinctive and unerring. Everyone who heard her concurs in the verdict: for pure vocal quality, signora Catalani has had no rival within living memory. La Banti, la Correa, Mrs Billington, Marchesi, Crivelli—not one of them can hold a candle to her. Even in the most brilliant of *coloratura* arias she creates the effect of *singing in a grotto*; every note has a *silvery reverberation*. . . .

What marvels, then, were it our fortune to witness, had nature but seen fit to bestow upon her the gift of a *soul*! But,

alas! in the event, she sang every single aria on the programme in exactly the same style. In anticipation, the aria

Frenar vorrei le lacrime . . .,

so gentle and so persuasive, was to have been the climax of the evening. Yet she sang it with the same profusion of tinkling and cascading *fioriture* as she had employed in the variations on the theme

Nel cor più non mi sento. . . .

In actual fact, signora Catalani's total repertoire comprises no more than a dozen items; with so slender an equipment does she tour the capital cities of Europe¹!

'One must hear her once, if only to experience the exquisite

¹ This evening's recital consisted of the following items:

Della tromba il suon guerriero . . ., by Portogallo

Frenar vorrei le lacrime . . ., by Portogallo

Nel cor più non mi sento . . ., by Paisiello

For the second recital, in Milan, the following items:

Dehl frenate le lacrime . . ., by Puccita

Ombra adorata, aspetta . . ., by Crescentini

Nel cor più non mi sento . . ., by Paisiello

For the third recital, the following items:

Della tromba il suon guerriero . . ., by Portogallo

Per queste amare lacrime . . ., by***

Oh! dolce contento . . ., by Mozart

For the fourth recital, the following items:

Son regina . . ., by Portogallo

Dolce tranquillità . . . Signora Catalani sings this aria in a trio with

Galli and with her pupil, Signorina Cori.

Oh cara d'amore!, by Guglielmi, also sung with Galli.

Sul margine d'un rio . . ., by Millico

Che momento non pensato . . ., a *terzetto* by Puccita, sung together with Galli and Remorini. In the event, Galli's voice completely eclipsed that of the peerless *prima donna*.

For the fifth recital, the following items:

Quelle pupille tenere . . ., by Cimarosa

Che soave zefiretto . . ., by Mozart

Stanca di pascolare . . ., by Millico

Frenar vorrei la lacrime . . ., by Portogallo

Là ci darem la mano . . ., by Mozart

Dolce tranquillità . . ., by***

nostalgia for what *might have been*, had nature not disdained to bestow a hint of sensibility in the neighbourhood of so astonishing a larynx. . . .’

‘It is fully eighteen years now since signora Catalani first came to Milan and sang

Ho perduto il figlio amato,

and she has not made an iota of progress!’

‘What does the composer matter? There *is* only one aria as far as signora Catalani is concerned—the one which *she* sings: an embroidered sequence of *fioriture*, nine-tenths of it in appalling taste. Since the day she left Italy, she has failed to find a single competent teacher. . . .’

This is a sample of the comments that I could hear exchanged all around me. And there is truth in every word of it. Yet, for all that, we shall scarcely hear the like again, as long as we live. She can sing ascending and descending chromatic scales better even than Marchesi, who was pointed out to me among the audience. He is still passably young, and enviably wealthy; and he still gives occasional concerts before a favoured company of friends; in this, he follows the practice of his rival Pacchiarotti in Padua. In his early days, Marchesi contrived to make himself the hero of a quantity of entertaining sentimental escapades.

This evening I heard the oddest tale, concerning a certain highly-respectable citizen of this province, whose misfortune it was to be afflicted with an unusually high-pitched voice. One night, just as he was about to pay a visit to a certain lady, no less notorious for the pettiness of her vanity than for the magnificence of her fortune, our squeaky-voiced friend was greeted with a hail of cudgel-blows about his person; the more he called for help, the higher his voice squeaked; and the higher he squeaked, the thicker the blows fell about him. ‘How now, hog of a *soprano*, that’ll learn you to come a-courting!’ The point is that the assailant was a priest, who was avenging a brother’s injuries upon the shoulders of our friend the highly-

respectable citizen, under the delusion that his victim was Marchesi. When the anecdote reached the ears of the *soprano* himself, he not merely dined out on it for half a year, but drew a timely moral from it for his own governance, and thenceforward steered his path very clear of this particular wealthy *bourgeoise*.

On the stage, signora Catalani, who must be thirty-four or thirty-five years old, still retains a remarkable degree of beauty; I could dearly wish to see her in *opera buffa*, where the contrast between the majesty of her features and the magnificence of her voice on the one hand, and the frivolity of the *rôle* on the other, must be profoundly striking. Whereas she will never grasp the first thing about *opera seria*. She is a creature of desiccated sensibility.

All in all, I was disappointed. I would gladly have journeyed ninety miles to hear such a programme; it was my good fortune to be actually in Milan. As soon as the recital was over, I whipped up the horses into a great gallop, to pay a call on Signora Bina R***; yet, by the time I arrived, I found I had already been forestalled by three or four *habitués*, who had run full tilt all the way from the *Conservatoire* so as to give the company, pessimistically chary of squandering its ten francs, a first-hand account of the evening. The distance involved was something over a mile and a half; nor was it therefore wholly surprising to observe a certain breathlessness about the conversation. I waited, by my watch, a full three-quarters of an hour, during which time not one single person managed to finish a sentence.

Naples is no longer the capital of the world of music; that pre-eminence is now usurped by Milan, at least in so far as music is a direct emanation of the passions. Give your Neapolitan audience a fine voice, and it is satisfied; Naples lies too close to Africa to appreciate the artistry which may portray the rarer shades of sensibility. Such, at least, is the picture I have just had painted for me by Signor de Breme.

7th October. I was forgetting to record the most striking impression of all at yesterday's recital by Signora Catalani; for several moments on end I was struck motionless with wonderment, for I had glimpsed the fairest countenance that ever I set eyes on. Its possessor is Lady Fanny Harley. *Raphaël, ubi es?* There is not one among the whole swarm of our wretched present-day artists, for all their load of trappings and titles, who can boast the technique to set on canvas such a face; their interpretation would forcibly be *modelled on classical antiquity*; it would *have style* (as they say in Paris)—in other words, it would impose an expression of strength and serenity upon features which owe their fascination precisely to the *complete absence of strength of any kind*. This apparent propensity to easy emotion, this expression of unsophisticated *naïveté* and gentle grace, is one of the most significant characteristics of certain modern faces, and the one which gives them so marked an ascendancy over the antique. But no contemporary artist could so much as begin to grasp the logic of this argument. How fortunate we might count ourselves, could we but set the clock back and return to the age of Ghirlandajo or Giorgione (1490)! In such an epoch, our artists might at least prove capable of executing a faithful copy of Nature, *as in a mirror*; and what a jewel beyond price would be a mirror wherein there dwelt an unfading portrait of Lady Fanny Harley, clad in all this evening's radiance!

8th October. I have no idea why the sight of supreme beauty threw me last night into such a maze of metaphysical notions. O, the pity of it, that the concept of *ideal beauty*, in relation to the form of the human head, should have gained currency in the world only *after* the death of Raphael! The burning sensibility of this great artist alone could have worked the perfect fusion of abstract idealism with natural reality. The pretty, sophisticated wit of our socially-lionised painters never reaches within a thousand leagues of the problem. If only they

could bring themselves, just once in a while, to condescend to make a faithful drawing from the life, without the inevitable *stiffening* (however devoutly borrowed from the Greeks), they might yet achieve greatness *all unawares*. Fra Lippo Lippi, now, or Fra Angelico of Fiesole, if nature had offered them a glimpse of a head so angelic as that of Lady Fanny Harley, would have asked for nothing better than to copy it faithfully. This is the reward and fascination of studying painting in the second half of the fifteenth century. I can fully appreciate what force urged Herr Cornelius and other artists of the German school to model themselves on this period. Indeed, who would *not* prefer Ghirlandajo to Girodet?

20th October. Unless I manage to leave here within three days, I shall never make my tour of Italy; not that I am entangled in any sentimental adventure, but merely that I am now on such footing of familiarity in four or five boxes at *la Scala*, that I am received as though I were a friend of ten years' standing. Nobody gets up when I come in, and the conversation continues as though none had entered save the footman. 'And *that's* something to be proud of, I'm sure!' I can hear the scandalised voice of my Parisian acquaintances. 'Gross discourtesy, in *our* opinion!' It may be so, indeed; yet, in my estimation, it is the sweetest reward in all the world for the two years I once spent learning, not merely the classical Italian of Tuscany, but the dialects of Milan as well, and of Piedmont, Venice, Naples and the rest. Beyond the frontiers of Italy, even the names of these dialects are unfamiliar, and they are spoken exclusively within the boundaries of the principality whose name they bear. Nevertheless, if you are deaf to the niceties of Milanese, the people among whom you have elected to travel are fated to remain both intellectually and emotionally invisible. The overbearing chatter and the brash impertinence which characterise the young blades of a *Certain Nation* inspire nothing but a shudder of revulsion in Milan. By a whim of chance, I

genuinely prefer listening to talking; and this constitutes a positive advantage, which sometimes redeems even my rarely disguised inability to suffer fools gladly. When I was in Paris (and this is a further confession I owe to the reader), a lady of fashion and intelligence once confided to me in a letter that there was something *rustic* about me. In all likelihood, it is this same taint of character which explains how it came about that the plainspoken informality of Italy so promptly won me heart and soul. What unspoilt simplicity! How directly words convey what each one is feeling or inwardly thinking *at the instant*! And how plainly it is apparent that no one is trying to *imitate* anyone else. Once, when I was in London, an Englishman said to me, referring to the mistress who was the idol of his heart: 'In all she is or does, there is never a hint of *vulgarity*'. It would take me a week to explain the meaning of this exclamation to a Milanese; but once he had grasped the elusive core of it, the joke would set him laughing for hours on end. I should be forced to begin by explaining that England, unlike Milan, is a land where men are penned and segregated into *castes*, as in India . . . etc., etc.

'The *informality of Italy*!'—I can hear the sneer of my friends from the Faubourg Poissonnière—'Did you ever hear such nonsense?' Yet the art of being natural, or simple, or candidly impassioned (if I dare use the phrase), is a *nuance* which attaches to every action that a man may perform; and consequently, I ought by rights to digress at this point with a description twenty pages long of the divers and manifold aspects of behaviour of which I have lately been witness. Such a description, contrived with due attention to style, and with all that scrupulous exactitude of detail which is my particular pride, would take a considerable time in the writing, and the clock in the tower of *San Fedele* has just struck the third hour after midnight. And besides, three out of every four of my readers would dismiss any such description as the purest fantasy. I shall therefore content myself with a plain statement of fact: there

is something here that is most singularly worth seeing, and which *can* be seen, by all who have eyes to see; but to make an invisible world visible, a sound knowledge of Milanese dialect is essential. If ever Béranger, the great poet, passes this way, *he* will understand what I mean. But Saint-Lambert, the poet of *les Saisons*, the court-parasite of King Stanislas, the only-too-favoured lover of Madame du Châtelet—Saint-Lambert would have found this land a torture and a desolation.

25th October. This very evening, signora Bibin Catena, a woman radiant with beauty, intelligence and *joie de vivre*, condescended to teach me the gentle art of playing *tarocchi**. This is one of the most obsessive preoccupations of the Milanese. It is a game which requires a full pack of fifty-two cards, each one three times the size of our own familiar variety. A score or more have attributes similar to the aces in an ordinary pack, and can beat any other card; they are beautifully designed, moreover, with symbols representing the Pope, Pope-Joan, the Jester, the Hanged Man, the Lovers, Fortune, Death, etc. There are, however, four suits (*bastoni*, *danari*, *spade*, *coppe*) just as in other games, pictured respectively by staves, coins, swords and goblets. Signor Reina, one of the friends whose acquaintance I owe in the first place to the kindness of signora G***, told me that this game was originally invented by Michelangelo. This same Signor Reina has brought together one of the finest libraries in Europe; he is, moreover, of an extremely generous disposition—an uncommon phenomenon, and one which I never before recall having discovered in alliance with a passion for books. He was among those deported to the Delta of the Cattaro in 1799.

If there be indeed a grain of truth in the claim that it was Michelangelo who invented the game of *tarocchi*, that moment of inspiration has proved an abundant source of quarrels ever since among the Milanese, and fair grounds for scandal in the eyes of such vain and mettlesome Frenchmen as deign to visit

the city. I met one of the latter breed this evening, in whose opinion the Italians were the unmanliest of creatures for failing to draw swords a score of times at least in the course of a game of *tarocchi*. And indeed, having been created, in an evil hour, almost totally bereft of vanity, the Milanese set no bounds to the uninhibited ferocity of the quarrels which arise among them over cards. In other words, they enjoy *tarocchi* as the occasion for the liveliest outbursts of emotion. This very evening, there came an instant when I was convinced that all four players in the box where I sat were about to grab handfuls of each other's hair; as it was, the game came to a standstill for a full ten minutes. The pit began to lose patience, calling out: 'Zitti! zitti!' and to tell the truth, since the box was no further removed than the second tier, the whole performance on the stage was, to all intents and purposes, being interrupted by the quarrel. 'Va a farti buzzarare!' shouted one of the card-players. 'Ti te sei un gran cojononon!' retorted another, his eyes afire with fury and screaming at the top of his voice. The twist of inflexion which fell upon the word *cojononon* struck me as a masterpiece of comic realism. Such storms of anger may seem excessive; yet they leave so little trace of their passage that I noticed, as we all left the box, that none of the parties to the quarrel seemed to feel the slightest need to apologise, or to smooth the matter over with his erstwhile antagonists. If the truth were told, the Italian who is genuinely angry is, so I believe, silent and self-controlled; and whatever tonight's manifestation may have implied, it was assuredly not anger. Rather call it *impatience*—the essential, comic, whirlwind impatience of two staid citizens quarrelling over a toy, and delighted to recapture a fleeting instant of childhood in the process.

Against the background of this lying and hypocritical generation ('this age of cant*', says Lord Byron), such wild displays of primitive and unsophisticated behaviour in the midst of the wealthiest and most aristocratic *élite* of Milanese society

left so indelible an impression on my mind, that I conceived the notion of coming to settle in Italy for good. Happiness is contagious.

My compatriot, devil take him! whom I could devoutly have wished at the bottom of the sea, came to pester me again later in the *Caffè dell' Accademia*, in front of *la Scala*. 'The vulgarity of it!' he exclaimed. '*Cojononon!* And the *shouting!* Come now, can you honestly claim that such a race has any refinement of sensibility? Or that their musical ear is offended by the slightest of discords?' Obviously, I *deserved* to see all my ideas desecrated by the tongue of a fool; it was my own fault for having talked unguardedly to him in the first place.

For it was *I* who first engaged in conversation with this Monsieur Mal***; and how bitterly have I lived since to regret it! I must tell the truth, though *National Honour* shall disown me for it, and cast me out for ever: when I am in Italy, the mere presence of a Frenchman spells the instant and unfailing annihilation of all my happiness. I am strolling in the gardens of Paradise, drowsy with the taste of dreams, enchanted with the folly and sweetness of make-belief; there comes a tug at my sleeve, and there he stands beside me, reminding me that it is cold and raining and well past midnight, that there are no lamps in the street where we are walking, and that we shall probably get lost and fail to find our way back to the inn where we are staying, and maybe fall in with robbers into the bargain. This is precisely what happened to me this evening: the very neighbourhood of a compatriot is death to the life within me.

Is there any way of explaining this instinctive nervous reaction, or of analysing the charming propensity for destroying aesthetic delight which seems to emanate from the 'charm' of the average Frenchman? Could it be that this very 'charm' is jealous of a pleasure in which, through impotence, it has no share? Or is it not rather that it finds the whole thing merely affected and absurd*?

27th October. Signora Marini has managed to secure me a ticket for the ball which is being held this evening by the merchant guilds, in their own private *Casin' di San-Paolo*. No enterprise could have required more ingenuity. Armed with my ticket, and talking with the clipped accent of the Milanese, I have just managed to induce the doorkeeper to let me take a look over the premises. My tone of easy familiarity, which is indispensable here, taken together with the fact that I was a Frenchman, was in the end a more palpable inducement than the *mancia* (the tip).

The wealthy merchant-bankers of Milan, whose staid common-sense and attachment to the tangible advantages of luxury shorn of vain display suggest a temperament akin to that of the Dutch, recently opened a common fund, with some four hundred subscribers, with the object of acquiring premises in the *via San-Paolo*—a building of the type known in Italy as a *palazzo*, which they purchased at bargain price. It is an imposing mansion, built of age-darkened stone. The façade is not, as it would be in Paris, simply a flat wall-face. At street-level there is a pattern of arches in the Etruscan manner, surmounted by a row of pilasters about the first floor. The whole effect is not unlike that building known in Paris as the *Palais de la Chambre des Pairs*. As a result of the refacing operations which have recently been carried out on this latter edifice, the architecture has been ruthlessly denuded of all the glamour of its ancient memories—a most *tactful* procedure to have adopted in respect of a seat of aristocratic government! If ever the merchant-princes of Milan were to entertain the foolhardy notion of perpetrating such an outrage upon their own *Casin' di San-Paolo*, the plebian throng of cobblers and joiners whose shops crowd the remaining portions of the street, which is one of the busiest thoroughfares in the city, would have licked its lips in gloating anticipation.

The municipal authority of Milan includes a standing committee *di ornato*; this committee comprises four or five

citizens of outstanding reputation as connoisseurs of art, together with two recognised architects, and exercises its functions on an honorary basis. Whenever a householder proposes to remodel the façade of his property, he is required to submit his design to the municipality, which hands it over to the *commissione di ornato*. The committee considers the plan and reports back. If the landlord is proposing to erect something devastatingly ugly,¹ the members of the *commissione di ornato*, who are all persons of rank and consideration, make a point of pouring down scorn and ridicule upon the offender in every conversation. In such a society, amidst a people gifted with an *innate sense of beauty*, yet where the subject of politics is fraught with constant danger or despair, there is matter enough in the façade of a new building to sustain conversation for a month, before its precise degree of beauty is established to within a fraction. The ethical traditions of Milan are intensely republican; indeed, the whole of Italy today is nothing but an extension of the Middle Ages. There is more solid consideration attached to a fine *palazzo* in the heart of the city than to untold millions in banknotes. If the building has any pretensions to beauty, it will immediately be baptised with the name of its owner. Hence, if you ask the way, you will be told: 'The Law-Courts are in such-and-such a street, in the *casa Clerici*'.

In Milan, the true patent of nobility is conferred by the building of a fine *palazzo*. Ever since the days of Philip II, the Milanese have looked upon the *Government* as a species of predatory vermin, exclusively concerned with plundering the city of some fifteen to twenty millions a year; anyone who attempted a rational apologia for its authority would be treated as a lunatic; even the theoretical principles which might motivate any such apologia must necessarily seem incomprehensible and absurd. The *Government* weighs not so much as

¹ For instance, that wooden, bronze-lacquered façade behind the pillars of the *Théâtre Favart* [1826].